

GAME VISION DOCUMENT

Project Title:

Working Title:

(Final title to be decided during pre-production.)

Document Version:

Version 2.0

Document Type:

Game Vision Document (GVD)

Genre:

Third-Person Martial Arts Beat 'Em Up Adventure

Development Stage:

Creative Pre-Production

Target Platform:

Windows PC

Target Engine:

Unreal Engine 5

Camera:

Dynamic Third-Person Camera

Adaptive Combat Camera

Gameplay Style:

Single Player

Combat Driven

Narrative Supported

Art Style:

Stylized Realism

Combat Style:

Commercial Kung Fu inspired by traditional Chinese martial arts and Hong Kong action cinema.

Narrative Structure:

Functional Narrative

The story continuously supports gameplay progression instead of interrupting it.

Intended Player Experience:

A cinematic martial arts adventure where every encounter contributes to the player's growth as both a fighter and a person.

Document Purpose

This Game Vision Document establishes the creative foundation of the project and serves as the primary reference for every department involved in development. It communicates the game's vision, gameplay identity, artistic direction, narrative philosophy, and production goals to ensure every discipline works toward the same experience.

Rather than functioning as a detailed implementation guide, this document defines **what the game should feel like, what experience it should deliver, and what principles should guide decision-making** throughout production.

Every feature, mechanic, environment, animation, system, and narrative element should align with the vision described in this document.

GAME IDENTITY:

Elevator Pitch:

A young martial artist fights through an enemy-controlled district to rescue his kidnapped master, mastering meaningful combat techniques and carrying forward his mentor's legacy in a cinematic beat 'em up inspired by Hong Kong martial arts cinema.

Game Identity Statement:

This project is a **combat-driven martial arts adventure** that emphasizes player mastery over character statistics.

The game combines **fast-paced crowd combat, cinematic choreography, functional narrative, and meaningful progression** to create an experience where every fight serves a purpose beyond defeating enemies.

Players are not simply progressing through levels—they are advancing through a journey of discipline, growth, and perseverance. Every encounter contributes to Ren's evolution from an impulsive student into a worthy successor to his master's teachings.

The core identity of the game is built upon three interconnected principles:

Combat Mastery:

Victory is achieved through player skill, timing, positioning, and understanding of combat systems rather than numerical progression.

Relentless Pursuit:

Every objective, encounter, and level exists to move the player closer to rescuing Master Shen. Gameplay continuously reinforces forward momentum and determination.

Meaningful Growth:

Progression is represented through the **Master's Legacy** system, where every new combat technique is earned alongside a philosophical lesson, ensuring gameplay advancement reflects Ren's personal development.

Core Design Values:

Every decision made during development should reinforce these values.

Design Value	Description
Player Skill First	Success is determined by the player's understanding of combat mechanics rather than character statistics.
Purposeful Combat	Every encounter should have narrative and gameplay significance. Combat is never included merely to increase playtime.
Continuous Momentum	The experience should maintain forward progression with minimal interruption. Exploration, combat, and narrative should naturally flow into one another.

Design Value	Description
Meaningful Progression	New abilities should represent lessons learned through experience, not arbitrary upgrades.
Cinematic Presentation	Combat should be visually exciting while remaining responsive and readable for the player.
Production Awareness	Every system, environment, and mechanic should remain achievable within the team's production capabilities without compromising quality.

Project Vision Summary:

The project aims to deliver a martial arts experience where every punch, movement, lesson, and victory contributes to one central fantasy:

The player is not becoming more powerful. The player is becoming a true martial artist.

Unlike traditional action games where progression is measured through equipment or statistics, this project measures progression through understanding, discipline, and mastery.

Every mechanic should answer one question:

Does this help the player feel like they are earning the legacy of their master?

If the answer is **no**, the feature should be reconsidered.

Creative Keywords:

These keywords define the creative identity of the project and should guide every department throughout production.

Gameplay:

- Fluid
- Responsive
- Tactical
- Skill-Based
- Cinematic
- Expressive

Narrative:

- Functional
- Personal
- Determined
- Grounded
- Emotional
- Purposeful

Art:

- Stylized Realism
- Traditional
- Urban
- Authentic
- Lived-In

- Atmospheric

Player Experience:

- Mastery
- Discipline
- Growth
- Momentum
- Heroism
- Legacy

VISION STATEMENT:

Vision Statement

This project is a third-person martial arts beat 'em up adventure that delivers the fantasy of becoming a disciplined martial artist whose greatest strength comes not from power, but from perseverance, mastery, and the lessons earned through every challenge.

Players experience the journey through the eyes of **Ren**, an impulsive young disciple whose master is kidnapped by a powerful martial arts syndicate. Determined to rescue the person who gave his life purpose, Ren fights through enemy-controlled territory where every encounter becomes another step toward reclaiming his master's legacy.

Rather than rewarding players with simple power progression, the game is built around **meaningful growth**. Combat mastery, environmental exploration, and narrative progression work together through the **Master's Legacy** system, where each lesson learned transforms both Ren's fighting style and his understanding of martial arts.

The experience combines:

- Fluid martial arts combat
- Cinematic action choreography
- Crowd-control encounters
- Purposeful exploration
- Environmental storytelling
- Functional narrative
- Skill-driven progression

Every system exists to support one emotional outcome:

The player should feel that every lesson, every victory, and every challenge shapes them into a true martial artist.

Creative Vision:

The game is designed to recreate the emotional progression found in classic Hong Kong martial arts cinema.

Rather than presenting the player as an unstoppable hero from the beginning, the experience focuses on earning mastery through repeated challenges, disciplined learning, and personal growth.

Combat should feel expressive.

Progression should feel meaningful.

Narrative should motivate gameplay instead of interrupting it.

Every department should contribute toward creating a seamless experience where story, mechanics, art, animation, and level design reinforce the same central fantasy.

HIGH CONCEPT:

One Sentence High Concept

A determined martial arts disciple battles through enemy-controlled territory to rescue his kidnapped master, mastering every lesson along the journey until he becomes worthy of carrying on his master's legacy.

High Concept Overview:

The game follows Ren, a martial arts student whose peaceful life changes when his academy is attacked by a powerful martial arts syndicate.

After witnessing his master's kidnapping, Ren begins a relentless pursuit through increasingly dangerous enemy-controlled territory.

His journey is not simply about defeating stronger opponents.

Every confrontation teaches a new lesson.

Every environment reveals another piece of the enemy's influence.

Every victory transforms Ren from an impulsive student into a disciplined martial artist capable of carrying forward his master's legacy.

The player's objective is therefore both external and internal.

Externally, rescue Master Shen.

Internally, become worthy of everything he taught.

GAME OVERVIEW:

Overview:

This project is a **combat-driven action adventure** that combines fast-paced martial arts gameplay with a narrative designed to continuously support player progression.

Unlike traditional beat 'em ups where combat encounters exist independently of the story, every encounter in this game has narrative purpose.

Enemies represent obstacles preventing Ren from reaching his master.

Levels represent stages of personal growth.

Bosses represent major milestones in Ren's development.

Progression represents understanding rather than increasing numerical strength.

The experience is built around four interconnected systems:

Combat:

The primary form of interaction.

Players defeat groups of enemies using fluid Kung Fu techniques, environmental interactions, counters, dodges, and cinematic finishers.

Every encounter rewards player mastery rather than statistics.

Progression:

Players do not simply unlock stronger attacks.

Instead, they recover pieces of **Master Shen's teachings**, gradually expanding Ren's abilities while reinforcing his emotional and philosophical growth.

This system forms the foundation of the game's progression.

Exploration:

Exploration encourages players to move deeper into enemy-controlled territory while discovering environmental storytelling, hidden paths, optional encounters, and narrative details.

Exploration always serves gameplay progression.

It never distracts from the player's objective.

Narrative:

The project follows a **Functional Narrative** philosophy.

Story exists to motivate gameplay rather than interrupt it.

Narrative moments establish stakes, introduce new challenges, reinforce player motivation, and reward progression without reducing gameplay momentum.

Core Gameplay Experience:

Players should experience a continuous cycle of:

- Entering enemy territory
- Reading the environment
- Engaging groups of opponents
- Adapting combat strategies
- Learning from each encounter
- Earning new teachings
- Progressing deeper toward the objective

This rhythm should remain consistent throughout the entire experience.

GENRE:

Primary Genre:

Third-Person Martial Arts Beat 'Em Up:

The game focuses on close-quarters combat against multiple opponents using expressive martial arts techniques, positioning, crowd control, and environmental interaction.

Combat encounters emphasize timing, movement, and mastery over numerical progression.

Secondary Genres:

Martial Arts Action Adventure:

Players progress through interconnected environments while uncovering narrative events and pursuing clear objectives.

Combat Mastery Experience:

Progression is determined primarily through player improvement, mechanical understanding, and disciplined execution.

Narrative Action Experience:

The story continuously motivates gameplay progression and reinforces player growth without interrupting the overall combat flow.

Cinematic Action Experience:

Combat, animation, camera behaviour, and environmental presentation are designed to evoke the pacing and choreography of Hong Kong martial arts cinema.

Genre References:

The following projects serve as reference points for specific aspects of the experience.

Reference	Primary Inspiration
Sifu	Combat rhythm, encounter pacing, level progression
Yakuza 0	Combat expression, cinematic finishers, crowd encounters
Sleeping Dogs	Urban martial arts fantasy, environmental combat
Judgment	Detective-inspired environmental presentation and grounded action
Ip Man (Film Series)	Martial arts philosophy and choreography
The Raid	Relentless progression through hostile territory
John Wick	Continuous combat momentum and encounter intensity

CORE GAMEPLAY:

Core Gameplay Philosophy:

The gameplay is built around the philosophy that **every action should contribute to the player's growth as a martial artist.**

Players continuously move through enemy-controlled territory, overcoming increasingly difficult encounters while learning new techniques, adapting to stronger opponents, and progressing toward rescuing Master Shen.

Rather than separating exploration, combat, and narrative into isolated systems, Dispatch integrates them into one continuous experience where each element supports the next.

The gameplay is designed to reward:

- Observation
- Timing
- Positioning
- Adaptation
- Discipline
- Continuous improvement

Success should always feel earned through player mastery rather than character statistics.

Core Gameplay Pillars:

The gameplay experience is built around four interconnected activities.

1. Explore:

Players navigate through interconnected enemy-controlled environments while searching for the path toward their objective.

Exploration focuses on:

- Reading the environment
- Finding progression routes
- Discovering environmental storytelling
- Preparing for upcoming encounters
- Linear path

Exploration should always create anticipation rather than distraction.

2. Engage:

Combat begins when players enter enemy-controlled spaces.

Each encounter is carefully designed to encourage:

- Crowd management
- Positioning
- Timing
- Flow
- Adaptation

Every encounter should introduce a new combat problem rather than simply increasing enemy numbers.

3. Learn:

Every major encounter teaches something new.

Learning comes from:

- Enemy behaviour
- New combat situations
- Environmental layouts
- Boss patterns
- Master's Legacy lessons

Players should continuously feel that they are improving their understanding of combat.

4. Progress:

After overcoming each challenge, players earn the opportunity to move deeper into enemy territory.

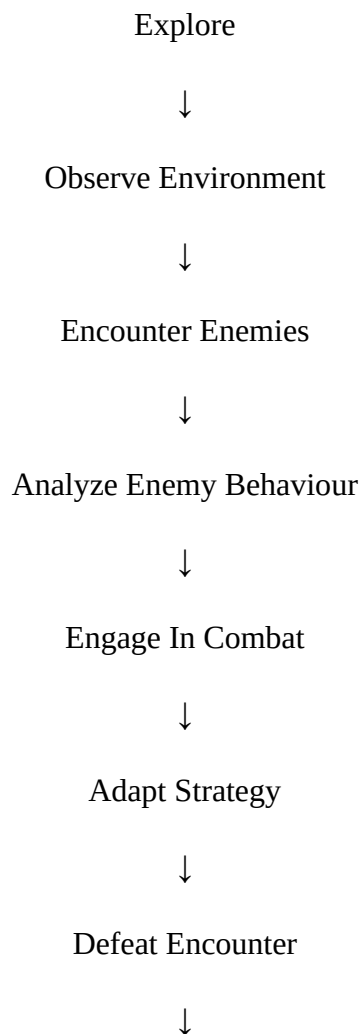
Progress is rewarded through:

- Narrative advancement
- New combat techniques
- New environmental challenges
- Increased enemy complexity

Progression should always reinforce momentum.

GAMEPLAY LOOP:

The core gameplay loop represents the repeated experience players will encounter throughout the game.



Recover Master's Teaching



Progress Deeper



Face Greater Challenge



Repeat

This loop reflects both gameplay progression and Ren's personal journey.

Gameplay Loop Philosophy:

Every completed encounter should answer three questions:

Did the player improve?

Success should result from increased player understanding rather than stronger character statistics.

Did the player learn?

Each encounter should introduce a new combat lesson, enemy behaviour, or environmental challenge.

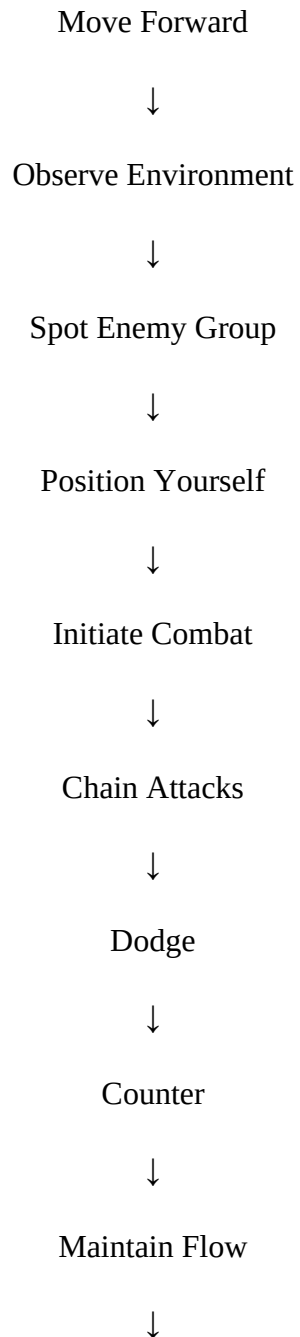
Did the player move closer to the objective?

Every encounter should feel meaningful because it contributes directly to Ren's pursuit of Master Shen.

MOMENT-TO-MOMENT EXPERIENCE:

Moment-to-moment gameplay defines what the player experiences during a typical gameplay sequence.

A typical encounter should follow this rhythm:



Finish Encounter



Observe Environment Again



Continue Forward

This sequence should feel continuous and uninterrupted.

Combat Rhythm

The player should constantly alternate between:

- Movement
- Positioning
- Attacking
- Defending
- Reading Enemy Intentions
- Repositioning
- Executing Finishers

Downtime should be minimal.

Momentum should remain consistent.

Emotional Journey (Asking feedback)

During a single encounter, players should experience:

Curiosity

"What am I walking into?"



Tension

"How should I approach this?"



Focus

"I understand this encounter."



Confidence

"I'm controlling the fight."



Satisfaction

"I've earned this victory."

PLAYER ABILITIES:

Player abilities define every action Ren can perform.

These abilities form the foundation of gameplay systems and animation production.

Movement:

Ren can:

- Walk
- Jog
- Sprint
- Change Direction Quickly

- Vault Small Obstacles
- Climb Short Obstacles
- Drop From Small Heights
- Turn Smoothly
- Interact With Objects

Movement should feel agile, responsive, and athletic.

Combat

Ren's combat abilities include:

Offensive

- Light Attack
- Heavy Attack
- Combo Chains
- Running Attack
- Air Finisher (*if applicable*)
- Environmental Attack (*if applicable*)
- Grab & Throw (*optional based on scope*)
- Finisher

Defensive

- Block

- Dodge
- Perfect Dodge
- Counter
- Recovery

Crowd Control :

- Push
- Sweep
- Reposition
- Enemy Redirect

These abilities encourage battlefield awareness rather than focusing on individual enemies.

Interaction:

Players can interact with:

- Doors
- Gates
- Training Equipment
- Story Objects
- Environmental Clues
- Collectibles (*optional*)

Interactions should support pacing without interrupting gameplay.

Master's Legacy Abilities:

As Ren progresses, he earns new techniques through the **Master's Legacy** system.

Rather than unlocking arbitrary upgrades, every new ability represents a lesson learned from Master Shen.

Examples include:

- Perfect Counter
- Sweep Kick
- Palm Strike
- Crowd Control Technique
- Advanced Combo Chain
- Master Technique

Each technique expands the player's combat expression while reinforcing Ren's personal growth.

Player Progression Through Gameplay:

At the beginning of the game, Ren relies primarily on instinct and foundational martial arts training.

As the journey progresses:

- Combat becomes more fluid.
- New techniques increase tactical options.
- Encounters demand greater discipline.
- Players express themselves through increasingly sophisticated combat.

By the end of the journey, Ren should not simply feel stronger.

He should feel like a complete martial artist.

Gameplay Design Principles:

Every gameplay feature introduced during development should satisfy the following principles:

- **Supports Player Mastery** — Encourages learning and skill development.
- **Maintains Combat Flow** — Preserves continuous momentum between movement and combat.
- **Provides Meaningful Choice** — Offers tactical decisions rather than a single optimal solution.
- **Reinforces the Narrative** — Reflects Ren's journey and Master's Legacy.
- **Fits the Production Scope** — Can be implemented, polished, and tested within the team's vertical slice.

COMBAT IDENTITY:

Combat Philosophy:

Combat is the heart of the player experience. Every encounter should make players feel like they are participating in a fast-paced Hong Kong martial arts film where victory is achieved through discipline, positioning, timing, and continuous adaptation.

Combat should never feel random or chaotic. Every enemy, arena, and mechanic exists to challenge the player's understanding of the combat system while encouraging mastery through repeated practice.

Unlike games that reward raw aggression, the combat in this project rewards thoughtful decision-making. Players who observe enemy behaviour, maintain positioning, and preserve combat rhythm will consistently outperform those who rely on repetitive attacks.

Combat is not simply about defeating enemies.

Combat is the player's method of expressing everything Ren has learned throughout his journey.

Combat Design Principles:

Every combat system should support the following principles.

Mastery Over Power

Player success is determined by mechanical skill, timing, and decision-making rather than numerical progression.

Combat Flow:

Movement, attacks, dodges, counters, and finishers should transition naturally without interrupting player momentum.

Combat Expression:

The player should have multiple solutions to every encounter.

Different combinations of positioning, counters, dodges, finishers, and environmental interactions should allow players to develop their own fighting style.

Meaningful Encounters:

Every encounter should introduce a new combat challenge.

Enemy placement, arena layout, and combat pacing should evolve throughout the game rather than relying on larger enemy groups.

Core Combat Systems:

The combat experience is built around interconnected mechanics.

Offensive Systems:

- Light Attack Chains
- Heavy Attacks
- Combo Routes

- Running Attacks
- Finishers
- Environmental Attacks

Defensive Systems

- Block
- Dodge
- Perfect Dodge
- Counter
- Recovery

Crowd Control

Because the player regularly faces multiple opponents, crowd management becomes a core skill.

Players should learn to:

- Control positioning
- Avoid being surrounded
- Separate enemy groups
- Create combat space
- Maintain battlefield awareness

Combat Success Criteria:

Players should finish encounters thinking:

"I understood the fight."

"I adapted."

"I earned that victory."

Not:

"I won because my character was stronger."

EXPLORATION IDENTITY:

Exploration Philosophy:

Exploration exists to support gameplay progression rather than distract from it.

Players are always moving toward a clear objective while discovering environmental storytelling, hidden opportunities, and new combat encounters.

Exploration should create curiosity and anticipation without interrupting the game's pacing.

Purpose of Exploration:

Exploration allows players to:

- Discover hidden routes.
- Understand the environment.
- Learn about the enemy syndicate.
- Observe visual storytelling.
- Prepare for upcoming encounters.

Every area should reinforce the feeling that the player is infiltrating hostile territory.

Exploration Design Principles:

Clear Direction:

Players should naturally understand where to progress through environmental composition, landmarks, and lighting.

Reward Curiosity:

Players who explore should discover optional story elements, hidden training relics, or visual details that enrich the world.

Maintain Momentum:

Exploration should never feel disconnected from the player's objective.

The player should always feel they are moving closer to rescuing Master Shen.

Environmental Storytelling:

Rather than relying on dialogue, the world should communicate information through:

- Architecture
- Props
- Damage
- Training equipment
- Enemy occupation
- Lighting
- Visual contrast

The player should understand the history of each location simply by observing it.

PROGRESSION SYSTEM:

Progression Philosophy

Progression represents Ren's growth as a martial artist rather than an increase in raw power.

Every improvement should reflect experience, discipline, and understanding.

The player does not become stronger because numbers increase.

The player becomes stronger because they learn.

Master's Legacy System:

The central progression system is **Master's Legacy**.

Instead of unlocking random combat upgrades, Ren earns new teachings from the philosophy of his master.

Each lesson contains three connected elements.

Philosophy:

A teaching that reflects Master Shen's beliefs about martial arts and life.

Technique:

A new combat mechanic or fighting technique that expands player expression.

Growth:

A visible improvement in Ren's maturity, discipline, and fighting style.

Progression Goals:

By the end of the experience, players should feel that they have:

- Learned meaningful combat techniques.

- Improved their understanding of encounters.
- Developed confidence through practice.
- Become worthy of carrying Master Shen's legacy.

FUNCTIONAL NARRATIVE PHILOSOPHY:

Narrative Philosophy:

This project follows a **Functional Narrative** approach.

Story exists to support gameplay, not replace it.

Narrative moments motivate player action, introduce new gameplay objectives, reinforce emotional stakes, and strengthen the player's connection to Ren's journey.

Gameplay remains the primary method of storytelling.

Role of Narrative:

Narrative serves four purposes.

Motivation

Give the player a clear reason to move forward.

Context

Explain why combat encounters exist.

Progression

Mark important milestones in Ren's journey.

Emotional Reward

Strengthen the player's attachment to Master Shen, Ren, and the world.

Narrative Integration:

Story should be delivered through:

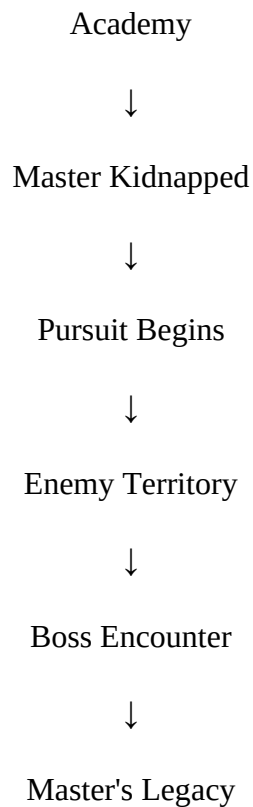
- Introductory cinematics.
- Brief in-game cutscenes.
- Environmental storytelling.
- Boss encounters.
- Master's Legacy lessons.

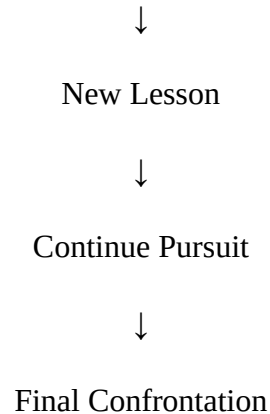
Long interruptions should be avoided.

Players should spend most of their time playing rather than watching.

Narrative Structure:

The gameplay and story progress together.





Each narrative event should immediately lead into meaningful gameplay, ensuring that momentum is never lost.

Functional Narrative Goal:

By the end of the game, players should feel:

"Every fight had a purpose, every lesson had meaning, and every step brought me closer to becoming the martial artist my master believed I could be."

DESIGN PILLARS:

The Design Pillars establish the creative foundation of the project. Every gameplay mechanic, level, animation, enemy, narrative event, and visual feature should support one or more of these pillars.

Whenever a new feature is proposed, the team should evaluate it against these pillars. If it does not reinforce at least one pillar, it should be reconsidered or removed.

These pillars ensure that every department works toward delivering the same player experience.

PILLAR 01 — MARTIAL ARTS MASTERY

Experience Goal

The player should constantly feel that they are improving as a martial artist through practice, observation, and experience.

Victory should always feel earned through player understanding rather than numerical progression.

Every encounter should introduce a new lesson, encourage adaptation, or reinforce previously learned skills.

Players should leave each combat encounter believing they became a better fighter—not simply a stronger character.

Design Impact

This pillar influences:

- Combat Design
- Enemy Design
- Boss Design
- Level Design
- Difficulty Curve
- Player Progression

PILLAR 02 — COMBAT FLOW:

Experience Goal

Combat should feel continuous, responsive, and uninterrupted.

The player should naturally transition between movement, attacks, defense, and finishers without breaking rhythm.

Every encounter should create a sense of momentum that carries the player forward through the environment.

The player should constantly transition between:

- Movement
- Positioning
- Light Attacks
- Heavy Attacks
- Dodging
- Countering
- Repositioning
- Finishing

without interruption.

Design Impact

This pillar influences:

- Character Controller
- Animation Blending
- Camera Behaviour
- Enemy AI
- Combat Timing
- Input Responsiveness
- Level Encounter Design

PILLAR 03 — COMBAT EXPRESSION:

Experience Goal:

Players should feel that every victory belongs to them.

The combat system should provide opportunities for creativity, improvisation, and individual playstyles rather than forcing a single optimal solution.

Two players facing the same encounter should be able to approach it differently while both feeling successful.

Combat should encourage:

- Creativity
- Improvisation
- Experimentation
- Tactical Decision Making
- Personal Fighting Style

Player mastery should come from understanding systems rather than memorizing one sequence of attacks.

Design Impact

This pillar influences:

- Combo Design
- Counter System
- Environmental Combat
- Encounter Design
- Enemy Variety
- Player Progression

PILLAR 04 — CINEMATIC FINISHERS:

Experience Goal:

Every encounter should make players feel like the protagonist of a Hong Kong martial arts film.

Combat should remain visually exciting without sacrificing gameplay clarity.

Finishers should reward player mastery while creating memorable action moments.

The player should frequently experience moments that feel worthy of a cinematic trailer.

Design Impact:

This pillar influences:

- Camera Behaviour
- Finishers
- Motion Capture
- Animation
- VFX
- Audio Feedback
- Environmental Interaction

PILLAR 05 — MASTER'S LEGACY:

Experience Goal:

Every lesson should shape the martial artist within.

Progression should represent personal growth rather than increasing power.

Players should feel that every major milestone teaches them something meaningful through gameplay, philosophy, and narrative.

Rather than unlocking random abilities, players inherit Master Shen's teachings through the **Master's Legacy System**.

Every lesson consists of three connected elements:

- A Martial Arts Philosophy
- A Combat Technique
- A Personal Transformation

As Ren learns these teachings, his fighting style becomes more disciplined, his combat options expand, and his understanding of martial arts deepens.

By the end of the journey, players should feel that they have earned their master's legacy—not simply completed a skill tree.

Design Impact:

This pillar influences:

- Progression System
- Functional Narrative
- Boss Rewards
- Character Development
- Combat Unlocks
- Player Motivation

WORLD IDENTITY:

World Philosophy

The world is not simply a backdrop for combat.

It is a reflection of Ren's journey.

Every location should reinforce the emotional progression of the story while supporting gameplay, pacing, and environmental storytelling.

As the player moves deeper into enemy-controlled territory, the world should gradually shift from **peace and discipline** to **control and oppression**, and finally to **determination and confrontation**.

The environment itself should communicate this transition without relying on dialogue.

World Identity:

The game is set within a **Hong Kong-inspired Urban Martial Arts District**, where traditional martial arts culture exists alongside dense urban development.

This district was once a place where martial arts schools represented discipline, respect, and community. Over time, a powerful martial arts syndicate has expanded its influence, transforming many of these places into territories under its control.

Rather than portraying a city in its entirety, the game focuses on carefully designed locations that each serve a gameplay and narrative purpose.

Every environment should feel authentic, functional, and lived-in.

World Themes:

Every location should visually reinforce one of three emotional themes.

Discipline

Represents:

- Peace
- Tradition
- Respect
- Growth

Example:

- Jade Dragon Academy

Control

Represents:

- Occupation
- Power
- Fear
- Order through force

Example:

- Enemy-controlled compounds
- Security checkpoints
- Barracks

Legacy

Represents:

- Wisdom
- Sacrifice
- Determination
- Mastery

Example:

- Boss arenas
- Final confrontation spaces
- Sacred training areas

Environmental Storytelling

The world should tell stories without dialogue.

Players should understand:

- Who occupied this place.
- What happened here.
- How people lived.
- How the syndicate controls the area.
- How Ren's journey changes the world.

Storytelling should rely on:

- Architecture
- Prop placement
- Damage
- Lighting
- Materials
- Color
- Spatial composition

Every object should have a reason to exist.

LEVEL DESIGN PHILOSOPHY

Design Philosophy

Levels are designed as **combat journeys**, not simply collections of rooms.

Every environment should guide players naturally through exploration, combat, and narrative while maintaining a continuous sense of progression.

The objective is not to create large worlds.

The objective is to create memorable combat spaces.

Each area should introduce a new gameplay challenge while remaining visually connected through reusable modular architecture.

Core Level Design Principles

Forward Momentum

Players should always feel they are moving deeper into enemy territory.

Navigation should naturally encourage progression.

Combat-Driven Spaces

Every room exists because it creates an interesting combat scenario.

Environment first supports gameplay.

Then supports narrative.

Compression & Release

Alternate between:

- Tight corridors
- Medium spaces
- Open combat arenas

This creates pacing and prevents visual fatigue.

Visual Guidance

Players should understand progression through:

- Architecture
- Lighting
- Landmarks
- Environmental composition

Objective markers should be minimized.

Environmental Storytelling

Every combat arena should reveal information about the world before combat begins.

Players should learn through observation.

Modular Construction

Levels should be created using reusable modular kits.

Variation should come from:

- Layout
- Lighting
- Prop placement
- Encounter design

Rather than creating entirely new assets.

Encounter Philosophy

Every encounter should present a different combat problem.

Examples include:

- Open crowd fights
- Narrow corridor encounters
- Chokepoints
- Circular arenas
- Multi-entry rooms
- Elite duels
- Boss arenas

Enemy variety and level layout should evolve together.

Player Flow:

Every level should maintain this rhythm.

Explore



Observe



Prepare



Combat



Recover



Continue



Boss



Reward



Progress

Downtime should remain brief.

Momentum should remain high.

ART DIRECTION:

Artistic Vision:

The visual direction follows a **Stylized Realism** approach.

Characters and environments should feel believable while retaining strong silhouettes, readable combat, and cinematic presentation.

Visual realism should support gameplay clarity rather than pursue photorealism.

Artistic Pillars:

Readability:

Combat animations, enemies, and interactable objects must remain clear during fast-paced encounters.

Authenticity:

Architecture, props, costumes, and materials should respect traditional Chinese martial arts culture while supporting the fictional setting.

Production Efficiency:

The environment should rely on modular construction and reusable assets to maximize quality within the team's production scope.

Cinematic Composition:

Every environment should be framed as though it belongs in a martial arts film.

Strong silhouettes, directional lighting, and balanced composition should support dramatic gameplay moments.

AUDIO DIRECTION:**Audio Philosophy:**

Audio should reinforce every action performed by the player.

Sound is not only feedback.

It is part of the combat rhythm.

Players should understand impact, timing, and momentum through sound before they consciously process visuals.

Audio Pillars:**Combat Feedback**

Every strike should communicate:

- Weight
- Direction
- Impact
- Precision

Different attack types should sound distinct.

Musical Direction:

Music should evolve with gameplay.

Exploration

Minimal instrumentation.

Combat

Fast percussion.

Boss

Traditional Chinese instruments blended with modern cinematic orchestration.

The score should follow the player's emotional progression.

Silence:

Silence should be used intentionally.

Important narrative moments.

Boss introductions.

After difficult encounters.

Before major reveals.

Silence allows emotional moments to breathe.

WORLD DESIGN SUMMARY:

The world should never exist simply as scenery.

Every environment, prop, material, sound, and lighting decision must support three goals:

- **Gameplay** — Create memorable combat encounters.
- **Narrative** — Reinforce Ren's journey and the syndicate's presence.
- **Player Experience** — Maintain immersion, momentum, and emotional progression.

Players should feel that they are not simply travelling through levels—they are **fighting their way through a living martial arts world that changes in tone and meaning as they move closer to their goal.**

NARRATIVE SUMMARY:

Narrative Philosophy:

The story of the game is built around **discipline, perseverance, personal growth, and legacy.**

Rather than existing as a separate cinematic experience, the narrative is tightly integrated with gameplay, ensuring that every level, encounter, and boss fight contributes directly to Ren's journey.

The narrative follows a **Functional Narrative** approach where story motivates gameplay instead of interrupting it.

Story Overview

TO BE WORKED

CHARACTER OVERVIEW

Ren

Role

Playable Character

Character Summary

Ren is a disciplined martial artist whose greatest strength is not his physical ability but his willingness to learn, adapt, and persevere.

Although he begins the story already possessing advanced martial arts training, his greatest journey is internal rather than physical.

His combat style evolves alongside his understanding of martial arts philosophy.

Master Shen

Role

Mentor

Represents:

- Discipline
- Wisdom
- Patience
- Legacy

Although absent for much of the game, his influence remains present through every lesson Ren remembers.

The Syndicate Leader

Role

Primary Antagonist

Represents:

- Control

- Fear
- Power through domination

He acts as the ideological opposite of Master Shen.

Where Master Shen believes power should serve discipline, the Syndicate Leader believes discipline exists only to gain power.

TARGET AUDIENCE:

Rather than targeting players by age, the game targets players based on their motivations and preferred experiences.

Mastery Seekers:

Players who enjoy improving through practice and overcoming difficult challenges.

They enjoy:

- Skill-based gameplay
- Timing systems
- Learning enemy patterns
- Mechanical mastery

Martial Arts Enthusiasts:

Players who appreciate martial arts philosophy, choreography, and cinematic combat.

They enjoy:

- Kung Fu

- Martial arts films
- Traditional fighting styles
- Authentic combat movement

Action Adventure Players:

Players who enjoy progressing through handcrafted environments while pursuing a meaningful objective.

They enjoy:

- Exploration
- Boss encounters
- Narrative progression
- Environmental storytelling

Cinematic Action Fans:

Players who enjoy games that create memorable action sequences through animation, camera work, and presentation.

Player Motivations:

Players should be motivated by:

- Self-improvement
- Curiosity
- Determination
- Achievement

- Mastery
- Personal expression

PLAYER EXPERIENCE GOALS:

Every system in the game should reinforce the following emotional outcomes.

Skilled

"I won because I understood the combat."

Determined

"No matter how difficult the challenge became, I kept moving forward."

Focused

"I lost myself in the rhythm of combat."

Heroic

"I felt like the protagonist of a martial arts film."

Creative

"I solved encounters using my own fighting style."

Worthy

"I earned every lesson my master taught me."

Memorable

"I remember specific fights because of how they made me feel."

CORE FANTASY:

The central fantasy is:

Become a true martial artist by carrying forward your master's legacy through every lesson earned, every challenge overcome, and every victory achieved.

The Fantasy Is

- Mastery
- Discipline
- Growth
- Determination
- Legacy
- Heroism
- Continuous Learning

The Fantasy Is Not

- Becoming overpowered
- Saving the world
- Grinding statistics
- Collecting loot
- Defeating supernatural beings

The player's greatest reward is becoming a better martial artist.

THEMES:

Primary Themes

- Mastery
- Discipline
- Legacy
- Perseverance
- Responsibility
- Personal Growth

Secondary Themes

- Self-Control
- Mentorship
- Honor
- Sacrifice
- Identity
- Redemption

Every department should reinforce these themes through gameplay, visuals, animation, audio, and narrative.

VERTICAL SLICE SCOPE

Purpose

The Vertical Slice is designed to validate the game's core identity rather than demonstrate the full production scope.

The objective is to prove that the gameplay experience is engaging, polished, and emotionally compelling.

Included

- Jade Dragon Academy Tutorial
- Introductory Narrative
- Core Combat Systems
- Master's Legacy Progression (Initial Lesson)
- Enemy AI
- Mini-Boss Encounter
- Primary Boss Encounter
- Environmental Storytelling
- Stylized Realism Art Direction
- Dynamic Combat Camera
- Core Audio Implementation

Not Included

- Full City
- Complete Story Campaign
- All Combat Techniques
- Multiple Districts
- Side Activities
- Advanced Progression Systems
- Complete Enemy Roster

VERTICAL SLICE SUCCESS CRITERIA:

The project will be considered successful if players consistently express the following:

Combat:

"The combat feels responsive, satisfying, and rewarding."

Progression:

"Every new lesson felt meaningful."

Player Growth:

"I felt myself becoming a better martial artist."

Narrative:

"I want to rescue Master Shen."

World:

"The environment felt believable and worth exploring."

Overall Experience:

"I want to continue this journey."

If these responses are consistently achieved, the Vertical Slice has successfully communicated the game's vision.

FINAL CREATIVE GOAL:

The objective of this project is not simply to create another martial arts beat 'em up.

The objective is to create a martial arts experience where **gameplay, progression, narrative, level design, art, animation, audio, and player emotion work together to tell one cohesive story.**

Every encounter should teach something.

Every environment should communicate something.

Every lesson should transform the player.

By the end of the journey, players should not feel that they completed a series of levels—they should feel that they have **earned the legacy of a martial artist through discipline, perseverance, and mastery.**